

# Analogue Mechanics: Offline Brutalism

*Zero Sum* is designed to be played entirely offline, utilizing physical pen, paper, and physical tokens to simulate the suffocatingly real horrors of bureaucracy and hyper-capitalism. Digital tools are not required.

## 1. The Physical Debt Ledger

Each player is issued a **Debt Ledger Sheet**. This replaces the traditional “gold/currency” section of a character sheet. - **Red Ink and Black Ink:** Players are required to track their finances using red and black pens. Positive balances are written in black; debts are written in red. - **The Ledger as a Burden:** Every time a player buys ammo, pays a bribe, or gets billed for collateral damage, they must physically strike out their previous balance and write the new one. The paper should become messy, stressed, and overwhelming over the course of a campaign. - **Generational Debt:** When a character dies, the player does *not* throw away their Debt Ledger. They physically cross out the deceased character’s name, write their new character’s name at the top, and continue adding to the negative balance.

## 2. The Contract Signing (EULA)

Before any mission or major loan is granted, the GM must provide a physically printed **Standard Independent Contractor Agreement (EULA)**. - **The Ritual:** The GM slides the printed paper across the table. The players must physically sign the document with a pen. - **The Fine Print:** GMs are encouraged to hide brutal, mechanical penalties deep within the text (e.g., organ forfeiture, exorbitant interest rates, waiving rights to life-support if injured). If the players don’t read it before signing, the GM enforces the penalties mercilessly.

### 3. Physical Resource Tokens

Scarcity is a core theme. Numbers on a page are easily ignored, but physical tokens are not. - **Tracking:** Use pennies, poker chips, or actual metal casings to represent ammunition, and a different token to represent daily rations. - **Handing Over Tokens:** When a player fires their weapon, they must physically hand a token back to the GM. When they are out of tokens, they are out of ammo. This creates a tactile, rising panic as players watch their physical pile of survival resources dwindle.

### 4. The Analogue Market Crash Table



The Black Market Kiosk

Instead of a digital ticker, the GM rolls for Market Fluctuations in front of the players at the start of every session (or whenever they visit a vendor). - **The Market Roll:** Roll a D10 Dice Pool on the **Market Crash Table**. - **Outcomes:** A low roll means the market is stable (prices are standard). A high roll indicates a crisis (e.g., Syndicate blockade, Corporate tax hike), applying a percentage multiplier (e.g., +50%, +200%) to all basic goods like ammo and medicine for the duration of the session.

## 5. The Itemized Receipt

At the end of a session, instead of simply awarding “XP and Loot,” the GM physically hands each player a printed **Itemized Operational Receipt**. - The GM fills in the blanks: Gross Payout, Ammo Deductions, Bio-Hazard Cleanup, and Net Profit. - Players must then copy their Net Profit (which is often a negative number) onto their Debt Ledger in red ink.

### Metadata Exhaust & The Debt Ledger

Players must scrub their Metadata Exhaust using the physical Debt Ledger. By physically writing a new debt line item, a player reduces their Metadata Exhaust by 1. Alternatively, they can hand the GM an Analogue Market token to erase 1 Exhaust.